

A Modest Proposal for Security

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Abstract

Digital security is of utmost importance in the modern world, and yet security incidents are commonplace. A majority of security breaches involve a “human element,” indicating that software solutions alone are not enough to solve this issue. Therefore, we propose a solution to target this human element through means of negative reinforcement.

Introduction

Digital security is a big issue that impacts the world a lot. [1] Surprisingly, this is not a new idea, and many attempts have been made to fix it. Unfortunately, all have failed. [2] According to a 2025 report [3], 60% of security breaches involve a “human element,” such as falling for phishing attempts, giving strangers physical access to devices, not using multi factor authentication, etc.. While many solutions exist to harden security in software, little exists to prevent these human elements from coming into play.

Previous Solutions

It’s common knowledge that most data breaches involve large corporations, where information is consolidated and organized. [4] Those working at such companies may have little personal motivation to prevent data breaches. Therefore, our solution, as well as many previous ones, aim to target this lack of motivation through negative reinforcement.

Common solutions often involve termination of employment. The obvious issue is that the terminated employee could seek employment at another company and continue to cause security breaches. For an individual company, this may not be an issue. However, in our interconnected world, that other company could end up being one the original depends on.

A possible modification to this solution is to use a non-non-compete agreement, so the terminated employee can only seek employment (and therefore cause security issues) at competing companies. Unfortunately, the wording for the US legislation banning non-competes does cover non-non-competes as well.

[5] This also does not accomplish our goal in this paper, which is to reduce the amount of security incidents at a global scale.

Our Solution

We propose the use of capital punishment as a threat against users who fail to follow recommended security practices. This creates motivation for an individual to take proactive action against data breaches.

In the worst case-scenario, where users are not sufficiently motivated, this will remove problematic users from the ecosystem, leaving those who practice recommended security practices.

Implementation

Left as an exercise to the reader.

Obstacles

Currently, the biggest obstacles to implementing this in practice are local laws and regulations. However, precedent shows that this can be corrected in the future.

Conclusion

In this work we establish the ever-present issue of digital security, and propose a solution that will ideally prevent 60% of data breaches through means of capital punishment. This work is presented in the hope of creating leverage to change regulations so that this can be implemented.

References

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- [5] Non-Compete Clause Rule. Rin 3084-ab74. 2024. https://www.ftc.gov/system/files/ftc_gov/pdf/noncompete-rule.pdf.